local protests in Bandipore, thereby halting construction once again.[33] This time the protestors had targeted the project contractor, alleging that the project had violated environmental laws. This attempt at delay did not last long and the fourth step in sabotaging the project also failed.

The year 2013 was a significant year for the evergreen China-Pakistan relationship. The CPEC was announced and, in many ways, was the fulfilment of the full vision behind the commencement of the Karakoram Highway way back in 1959.[34] The full extent of this vision was later expanded in 2017 to include the construction of five dams forming the North Indus River Cascade that China had promised to finance and build in Pakistan and in POK.[35] The first dam would be built at Bunji near Skardu, and would have a 22 km long reservoir along the Indus. The second dam, the Diamer Bhasha Dam would have a live storage of 6.4 million-acre feet of water. The third dam in the cascade would be the Dasu Dam with a 74 km long reservoir along the Indus which will stretch all the way to the Diamer Basha Dam. The fourth dam would be a little distance downstream at Patan with a 35 km long reservoir that goes up to the Dasu Dam. The fifth dam would be a little downstream—the 4,000 MW Thakot Hydropower Project which would divert the Indus waters through four headrace tunnels to generate electricity.[36] By the time the Indus emerges from the tunnels, it will be close to the existing dam at Tarbela, which had been in operation since 1976.[37]

Clearly the question is, once electricity has been generated from water, would the water then be released for irrigation or would it be used to make microchips? If the latter is the case, then it explains Pakistan’s reaction to the Kishenganga project. Take the Indus out of the picture and you have to rely only on the waters of the Jhelum and the Chenab, both flowing through Jammu and Kashmir into Pakistan. Therefore, India’s resolve to complete the Kishenganga project had to be broken.

Aggressive action from Pakistan started in January 2016, when for the first time ever, terrorists from Pakistan crossed the border and attacked a military asset in India. This was the frontline Pathankot Air Force Station,